Find the claim behind the facts

Separate what someone wants you to accept from the reasons they offer.

Suggested teaching time: 15 min | Preparation: about 3 min

Introductory | Secondary and adult learners | Individual writing, pairs, and class discussion

Prerequisites: None

Students will be able to

- Identify the main claim without strengthening it.
- Distinguish a claim from supporting evidence and background.
- Explain a sentence's role using its connection to the proposed action.

Prepare and gather

- One student handout per learner, or display the activities and use paper.
- Pens or pencils; no student devices required.
- Instructor guide with model answers, kept separate from the handout.
- Read the three short scenarios and model answers.
- Print the three-page handout double-sided if convenient, or display one activity at a time.
- Tell learners that all scenarios are invented for reasoning practice; identifying a claim does not mean accepting it.

Teaching sequence

3 min	**Notice the proposed action.** Read the warm-up aloud. Learners write the proposed action and its reason, then compare with a partner. Use the vocabulary to name the distinction.
6 min	**Label the library argument.** Learners complete the main activity individually, then compare labels in pairs. Ask them to explain the role of the visit count rather than vote on the library policy.
3 min	**Discuss and check.** Reveal the main model answer. Use the discussion prompts to distinguish identifying the proposal from evaluating it. Correct labels by asking which sentence the other facts are meant to support.
3 min	**Check independent understanding.** Learners complete the exit ticket without their partner. Check it against the three assessment criteria before revealing the answer.

Timings are suggested starting points, not measured classroom completion times.

Warm-up / The bicycle rack proposal

Student task and instructor answer

Explain these words as needed

Claim: A statement someone asks an audience to accept. In these activities, the main claim is a proposed action.

Evidence: Information offered to support a claim.

Background: Context that helps describe the situation but is not itself offered as the main support.

Scenario

Invented scenario: A student says, 'Six bicycles were left against classroom walls today because the rack was full. The school should add another bicycle rack.'

Student output: Write two labelled sentences: one for the proposed action and one for its supporting reason.

1. Copy the action the student wants the school to take.

2. Copy the fact offered to support that action.

Student success check: Does your proposed action say what the school should do, while your reason describes what happened?

Model answer

Proposed action: the school should add another bicycle rack. Supporting reason: six bicycles were left against classroom walls because the existing rack was full.

Why this meets the task: The answer distinguishes a recommendation from the observation offered to support it. It does not claim that this is necessarily the best solution.

Main activity / The library's later closing time

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A student writes, 'Our library closes at 5 p.m. During a four-week trial of closing at 7 p.m., weekly visits rose from 400 to 460. The council should keep the later closing time.'

Student output: Write three labelled statements (claim, evidence, background) and one sentence explaining your labels.

1. Copy the main claim: the proposal the writer wants the council to accept.

2. Copy the supporting evidence and label the remaining sentence as background.

3. Write one sentence explaining why the visit count is not itself the main claim.

Student success check: Have you separated the proposed action from the fact used to support it? Do not add 'always' or claim that the trial proves the policy works everywhere.

Model answer

Claim: the council should keep the later closing time. Evidence: weekly visits rose from 400 to 460 during the trial. Background: the library normally closes at 5 p.m. The count supports the proposal; it is not the proposed action.

Why this meets the task: The answer names the roles of all three sentences without strengthening what the writer said. The rise in visits is relevant to the recommendation, but identifying its role does not establish that later closing caused the rise or outweighs the costs.

Exit ticket / The community garden proposal

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A resident writes, 'The community garden opened in 2019. All 20 planting plots are in use, and 12 residents are waiting for a plot. The council should create ten more plots.'

Student output: Write the claim, evidence, and background with labels; add one sentence explaining how the evidence relates to the claim.

1. Copy the proposed action exactly, including the number of additional plots.

2. Identify the fact offered in support and the fact supplying background.

3. Explain why the demand for plots is evidence for the proposal rather than the proposal itself.

Student success check: Have you kept the proposal at ten more plots and avoided adding a guarantee that everyone will receive one?

Model answer

Claim: the council should create ten more plots. Evidence: all 20 plots are in use and 12 residents are waiting. Background: the garden opened in 2019. The demand is offered as a reason to expand; it does not itself state what the council should do.

Why this meets the task: The answer preserves the exact proposal, identifies the supporting observation, and explains its role. It does not turn identifying a claim into proving that the proposal is sufficient or affordable.

Check understanding

Mark each criterion met or needs another attempt. Accept equivalent wording; assess the reasoning, not a memorized phrase.

- The proposed action is identified accurately without exaggeration.

- Evidence and background are correctly distinguished.

- The explanation connects the supporting fact to the proposal rather than merely repeating both.

Discussion and adaptations

Use the supplied guidance to keep the lesson focused on its reasoning skill.

Discussion prompts

Could someone identify the library claim correctly and still disagree with it?

Listen for: Yes. Identifying a recommendation and judging its merits are different tasks. Costs, staffing, or alternative explanations could matter when evaluating it, but they are not supplied here.

Why is the sentence with the most numbers not automatically the main claim?

Listen for: A sentence's role depends on what it supports, not on its length, detail, or numerical content.

Common confusions

A claim must be false or unsupported. A claim is something proposed for acceptance. It may be true, false, well supported, or poorly supported.

Evidence can never itself be a claim. An evidence statement can be a claim in another argument. Here we identify its role in supporting this main recommendation.

Finding the main claim proves the recommendation is good. First identify what is being proposed; then evaluate the evidence and other relevant considerations.

Adapt the lesson

More support: Read each scenario aloud and provide three labels to place beside the sentences: proposed action, supporting fact, background. Ask learners to explain one placement orally before writing.

More challenge: After the exit ticket, ask: 'Would changing the proposal from ten more plots to one hundred change the role of the demand figures, their strength as support, or both?' Expected response: their role stays evidence, but the stronger expansion proposal requires more justification.

Next practice

https://xixteen.com/learners/?practice=clarify_claim#workbench